2019b). Exiting an IO is not a casual decision; most institutions establish formal procedures that states must follow, including notifying other members and observing a probational waiting period—typically at least a year—before completing the process (Copelovitch and Putnam 2014). The United States encountered such a waiting period when exiting the Paris Agreement during Donald Trump's first term as president. Exit is also costly, sometimes leading to IO death (von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2024b).

Given its costliness, even the mere threat of withdrawal can serve as a powerful coercive tool. These threats are not idle; they often create significant bargaining leverage for leaders, forcing IOs to make concessions to retain their participation (Clark 2022). Donald Trump, for instance, frequently threatened to leave major institutions such as NATO and the WTO, which elicited proposed reforms and benefits from these institutions, as we detail in our case studies.

When a state publicly considers exiting, it may raise doubts about the organization's mission, effectiveness, and cohesion. The impact of such threats often hinges on their credibility, and populists' threats may be especially credible—their ideological and electoral motivations support disengagement from IOs, reducing the perceived costs of withdrawal and making their threats more destabilizing.

Despite their rhetorical fervor, however, populist exits from IOs are relatively rare because the costs of withdrawal are substantial. For the departing state, the process is typically protracted and politically contentious, drawing significant ire from other members. These exits are not isolated events—they carry the risk of a contagion effect, where the departure of one state inspires others to follow. This fear loomed large during Britain's exit from the EU and Greece's near-departure from the eurozone during the eurocrisis, as American and European officials worried about a domino effect (Clark 2025).

Leaving an IO also comes with immediate losses. States forfeit access to the economic, security, and informational benefits that membership provides (Keohane 1984; Davis 2023). IOs serve as hubs for negotiation, socialization, and intelligence sharing, and departing members lose their influence over these processes.[1] This absence from decision making can result in policy outcomes that diverge even further from the departing